

Issue 5

Cover: When Spring Comes, Ari Perez (M26)

NAPKINS

2024 Spring



Dearests,

Where do we fit in the world? What spaces do our bodies, minds, and actions occupy? As we went through the submissions for this issue to curate a narrative, we asked, what are all of them saying simultaneously? Beneath a lot of these reflective pieces, there lies a strong undercurrent of angst. And it comes across unintentionally, or perhaps intentionally for everything is interconnected, a reflection of and conversation with the world.

The world is rife with manmade cruelty. russia’s war in Ukraine continues; it has been over 800 days. We cannot escape the genocide happening in Gaza, where lives are reduced to numbers. We cannot unsee protestors demanding basic human rights for Palestinians being manhandled by police forces. Not to mention university administration calling on police to brutally handle peaceful student protestors. This cruelty also sinisterly manifests in the cowardly game of definition, where people-in-power in various institutions refuse to call the genocide for what it is: a genocide.

Angst is a difficult term; we often think of it as a teenage phase, a misstep where our mind is confused in wanting more/better/other. Angst is scary; angst is consuming; angst is unpredictable. This issue disillusions us from these associations. Angst runs deep in all of us. It gives space to a difficult-to-define layer where frustration, mourning, disillusionment, love, and longing meet. It gives a loud voice to reach for empathy and true partnerships where they feel lacking or false. In wildly looking for spaces to belong, we might find agency despite/within our family histories, heartfelt and heartbreaking conversations, and perhaps even safety.

This angst reminds us of the sentiment that has intensified in us as cruelty unfolded. In an issue with so many pieces touching on the human condition, it simply does not feel right not mentioning the grotesque human condition inflicted on Palestinians by the Israeli occupying forces.

As you flip through this issue, we invite you to contemplate the world around you. As you spread a picnic, think of those you’ve loved and love now; as you drop your chin, look – perhaps they soak through your skin in tattoos; as you turn your cheek halfway to an early spring sun to taste nostalgia; as you move and wriggle your body, take your hands and press them firmly in a hug around yourself.

Angst is about being desperately human. It’s good to be angry.

Yours,
Miss Chia & Miss Panasenko.

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as May approaches by Donatello (Staff)

a closed journal
teases a flip
the cover just thicc
enough



to avoid spillin over
to avoid watchin words
turn wave to wisp
a wind
writes
in the e m p t y



a blanket
beneath 2 feet
2 peaches, 2 pairs of hands
touching
parts
it's warm, winter gone summer not yet
come
we just sprung
young flames
sippin
slowly
like sap
& time
sometimes



usually
this heemyhorchata
feels like heartbreak
over martyrs made in the modern age
over innocence lost
over the baddie who rested on my shoulder
speaking poems
on BART
home,
it was
long ago...
over broken hearts
& mums who can't celebrate

today,
under an older sunlight
your tattoos soaking it in
this slightly watered down cup...
it's giving...
... recharge

& be remarkable



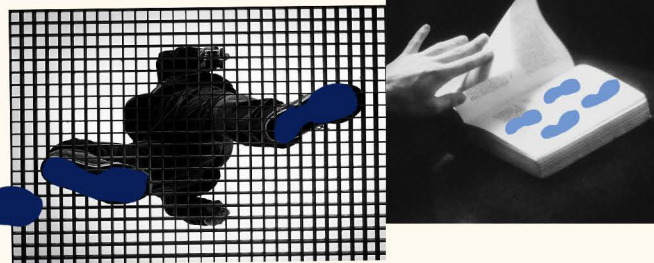
Day of a Stupid Man

By Christopher Fok

"I may wear the skin of an urbane sophisticate, but in this manuscript I invite you to strip it off and laugh at my stupidity." – Ryūnosuke Akutagawa

1. Longing

Sneakily, the overcast sky sinks darker into the evening. On Fridays, the library closes at 5.30 pm, though he didn't know. He plans to renew the book he still hasn't read for two weeks. Because a part of him ardently believes in a future where he would read it. After biking for twenty minutes and climbing up two flights of stairs, he stands behind the locked glass door, staring at the dimmed lights, abandoned books, and a deserted reception.



Perhaps this is arranged so that the staff can come home earlier for a hearty dinner? He thinks as he returns to his bike. Beef potato hash? Pork casserole with Worcestershire sauce? He makes random turns on his bike. Down the main street, left on an alley, and stopping before a crowd, he mindlessly ends up at Farringdon Station. Many are waiting outside. For their loved ones? For friends? He picks up a free hot chocolate, and stands in the chilling January wind. He too pretends to wait for someone.



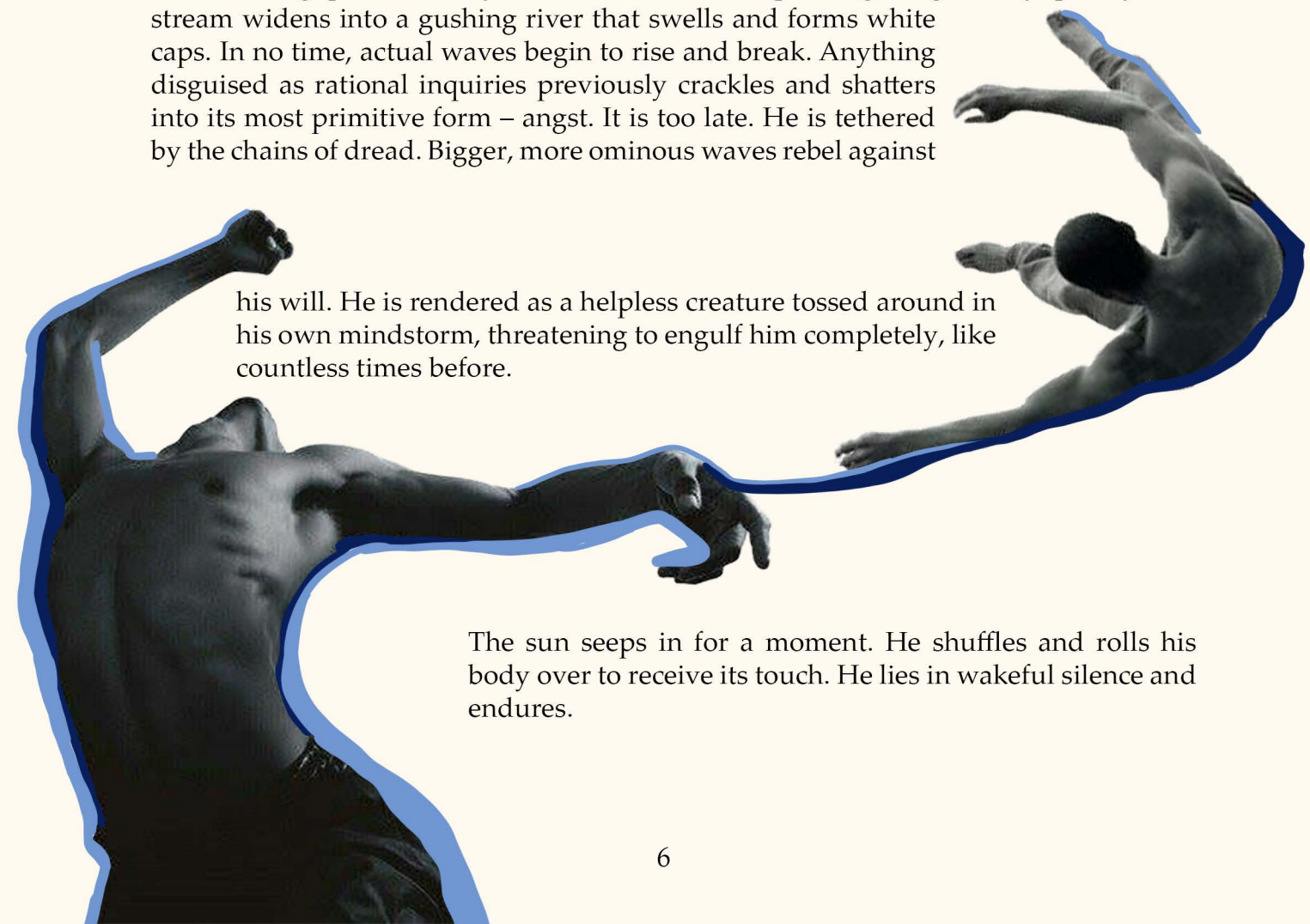
2. Paralysis

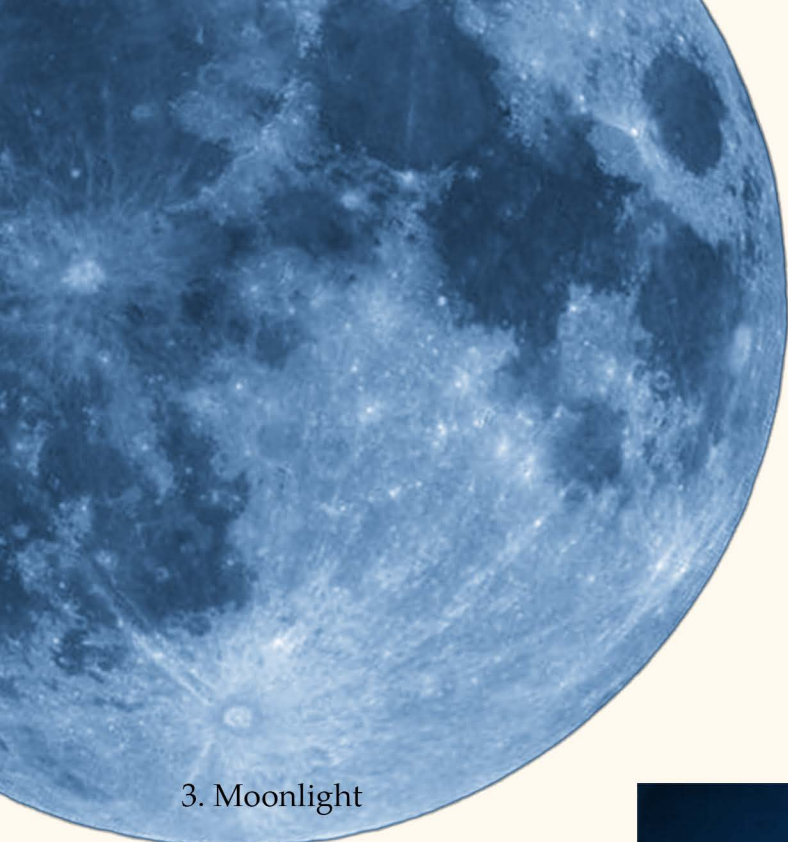
Dreams – intense. Evil hours – sporadic. Mentions of her name – torturous and unbearable. It is day three since he has been constrained to the couch. His left ankle just could not bear any weight. Even limping to the toilet requires enormous effort. Worse, the sun almost never visits him. On rare days, it does so by reflecting off the window of the gray-walled hotel that towers over his apartment and blocks all sense of the outer world.

In his solitude, thoughts start to enter unasked for, dripping into his consciousness like tiny droplets. As the droplet lands, it splashes and releases a specific feeling, which he is simply incapable of keeping out. So he tries to tally them: sometimes the fuzzy warmth of a nostalgic memory. Other times the sudden sink into grief. But at the end always the piercing feeling of incompetence and powerlessness. Every drop is so small and brief, yet so gratifying and painful. And as they drip faster and faster, the pauses between each become shorter and shorter. Until they start to form a little stream, he can no longer tell apart the colorful autumn of Seoul, the lonely streets of Tokyo, and the shivering wind of London within it. At this point, he is allured to succumb to its flow. One question leads to one memory that leads to another question, he finds himself both enlightened and entertained in the spiral. The beauty of autumn, would he have still let himself be enamored by it, if he knew the winter would be so unforgiving? But the never-ending questions only blind him from the impending danger. Very quickly, the stream widens into a gushing river that swells and forms white caps. In no time, actual waves begin to rise and break. Anything disguised as rational inquiries previously crackles and shatters into its most primitive form – angst. It is too late. He is tethered by the chains of dread. Bigger, more ominous waves rebel against

his will. He is rendered as a helpless creature tossed around in his own mindstorm, threatening to engulf him completely, like countless times before.

The sun seeps in for a moment. He shuffles and rolls his body over to receive its touch. He lies in wakeful silence and endures.





3. Moonlight

Soon the sun makes way for the moon and the sky dims into a deep dark navy. A train is snaking into Eunston station, hissing imaginary smoke out of its chimney. It's been a week, though his ankle still will not budge. Today, leaving the apartment feels as if an overpowering necessity. After spending an afternoon at University College London, he limps towards Eunston station (no biking, of course). Amongst the crowd in the backdrop of a clear night, his eyes are drawn to an East Asian man alone, perhaps in his early 30s, stepping out of the station.

Mr. A's hairstyle looks Korean, but he has the slow footsteps of a Japanese. To some, Mr. A can appear mechanical and rigid. But to him, Mr. A oozes a silent dignity. His gray suit is tailored perfectly to his skinny figure and his navy tie tightly hangs off the still-unbuttoned collar. Mr. A keeps his head low, fixing his gaze to the ground, as if on his shoulders carry an unknowable amount of weight. As he emerges from the shadow of the underground, the full moon, at an instant, bathes him in white light and grace, illuminating a face of sharp eyebrows and shallow wrinkles. It was a difficult day, wasn't it. But you made it, didn't you? A question for Mr. A that didn't leave his mouth in time. And as they brush past each other, a loneliness he never knew of overwhelmed him.

4. Lunatic

He starts frequenting the piano whilst at the library. For this, he must give up his identity card as a collateral to the librarian in exchange for a pair of headphones. As for the headphones, they are to be connected to the piano (it's electric). So that only the player can listen to his own poundings on the keys. And so that others in the library may not be disturbed.

For a while, he has been meaning to learn to play Un Sospiro by Franz Liszt, a piece that even he cannot believe truly touches his heart. But ultimately, he is a piano player of limited potential. His amateurism prevents him from perfecting his previous piece, Merry Go Round of Life by Joe Hisaishi, and proceeding from there.

He plays for twenty minutes. But he finds himself irritable and incapable of concentrating. So in dramatic fashion (no one is around really), he rips his headphones off and walks off. As the librarian returns his identity card, remarking how much he seems to enjoy playing from his constant swaying, a thought takes hold of him: no one could hear me.

5. Imagination

The rain has been beating down all morning, making the day seem like it has barely begun. He is reading on his phone about a type of double suicide in Japan called Shinjū. Two lovers, at odds with the society, believe they'd be reunited in heaven if they kill themselves at the same time. Osamu Dazai, the writer he has been reading, did exactly that. Twice. Because he failed to drown himself in Kamakura, while his lover, tragically, succeeded. It's not hard for him to reconcile that such an extreme act occurs in Japan.

He never thought of suicide. But for those who decided to end their lives, life must be so unbearable to live – a statement he has neither the authority nor the experience to back up. All he has is a glimpse. A glimpse so small of what true sadness is that he might as well keep to himself. At this point, the cream starts boiling. He puts down his phone

